



To what extent does Nancy Fraser's critique of Jurgen Habermas' "public sphere" provide a more inclusive framework for analysing media and cultural politics?

Jurgen Habermas's theory of the public sphere remains one of the most influential accounts of democratic communication in social theory. Its importance lies in the claim that democracy depends not only on elections, parties, or formal rights, but also on spaces in which citizens can discuss matters of common concern, form public opinion, and hold authority to account. In its classical form, the public sphere describes a space between civil society and the state "in which private individuals assemble to form a public body" and debate matters of common concern (Habermas, 2006: 73). In this sense, media institutions are not only channels that circulate information, but also part of the conditions that make public criticism possible.

In this essay, I argue that Fraser provides a more inclusive framework because she shows that the bourgeois public sphere was shaped by exclusion, inequality, and the boundary between public and private. Her emphasis on multiple publics and subaltern counterpublics is especially important for analysing media and cultural politics, since it helps explain how visibility, legitimacy, and exclusion are organised in public life. Despite this, Habermas remains valuable as a normative starting point for judging whether media and cultural institutions support democratic public communication.

I will begin my analysis with Jurgen Habermas' concept of the public sphere, as it offers a democratic account of why communication matters politically. In his works, rather than treating democracy only as elections, parties, legal rights, or state institutions, Habermas (2006) focuses on the social conditions through which citizens form public opinion and hold authority to account. In his concise definition, the public sphere is a realm where "public opinion can be formed" (Habermas, 2006: 73). It stands between the private realm of civil society and the formal institutions of the state. In this sphere, citizens do not act as consumers pursuing private interests or as subjects obeying administrative power. Instead, they take part as members of the public in discussions about matters of general concern. The political significance of this model is that public opinion should emerge through open debate rather than secrecy, inherited status, coercion, or manipulation.

This is why Habermas' model is also a theory of media. In large modern societies, public discussion cannot depend only on face-to-face conversation. It requires institutions and technologies that circulate information, arguments, and criticism beyond immediate settings. Habermas identifies newspapers, magazines, radio, and television as "media of the public sphere" (Habermas, 2006: 73). His historical account also shows how media and associational spaces enabled cultural discussion to develop into political criticism. Their importance lay in transforming publicity from something displayed by power into something that could scrutinise power. In other words, authority had to justify itself before a public capable of criticism. It treats communication as central to democracy and helps explain why exclusion from public debate is politically damaging.

At the same time, Habermas' own historical account shows how limited this universal ideal actually was. The public sphere he describes was not a general model open equally to everyone, but the historically specific bourgeois public sphere of eighteenth- and nineteenth-century Europe. Its apparent openness depended on conditions that were never truly universal. As Habermas (1989: 87) acknowledges, the political public was organised around "property and education", which meant that access to debate was closely tied to class position, literacy, leisure, and elite institutions.

This creates a central contradiction in Habermas' account. He notes that "the fully developed bourgeois public sphere was based on the fictitious identity" between property owners and human beings as such (Habermas, 1989: 56). To put it simply, the interests of bourgeois men were presented as if they represented everyone. As a result, particular classed and gendered interests could present themselves as universal reason. Women, dependents, the propertyless, and those outside elite print culture were excluded by the organisation of the public sphere itself. Even though they could sometimes participate more visibly in literary and salon cultures, the political public sphere remained shaped by property, education, and masculine authority. These exclusions do not make Habermas's model useless, but they do mean that it cannot be treated as a universal or fully inclusive account of democratic public life.

Jurgen Habermas also identifies a later transformation of the public sphere. The press had helped to support critical debate, but it became commercialised and absorbed into mass consumer culture. Advertising, public relations, concentrated ownership, and organised interests weakened rational-critical discussion. Habermas (1989: 142, 232) describes this as "refeudalization", where public communication becomes a "display of staged or manipulated publicity" rather than genuine public reasoning. This point is vital for analysing modern media. Still, it can also idealise the bourgeois past. For instance, John Thompson's article 'The Theory of the Public Sphere' reinforces this problem by arguing that applying Habermas to mediated societies requires us "to think again about what 'publicness' means in a world permeated by new forms of communication" (Thompson, 1993: 188).

The limits outlined above lead to Nancy Fraser's critique, which provides the essay's main critical framework. By rebuilding public sphere theory from the standpoint of inequality, she does not argue that Habermas' concept is irrelevant. On the contrary, she treats the public sphere as indispensable to democratic theory, but argues that Habermas' specific bourgeois model is "not wholly satisfactory" (Fraser, 1992: 111). In this way, her critique can be approached through three main points.

First, Fraser questions the bracketing of inequality. Although Habermas assumes that participants can set aside status differences and deliberate as peers, Fraser (1992: 115) argues that this is not enough, since declaring an arena to be one where status differences are bracketed is "not sufficient to make it so". Class, gender, race, sexuality, education, and status still shape who is ignored, believed, or treated as rational. These are "informal impediments to participatory parity" (Fraser, 1992: 119). This matters because inequality works inside communication itself. Public debate may privilege calm, abstract, and institutionally recognised speech, while anger, personal testimony, or community-based knowledge can be dismissed as emotional or too particular. Fraser accordingly shows that formal access is not enough: power also operates inside the rules and expectations of debate.

Her second point concerns publics themselves, or more precisely, their number and relation. Fraser challenges the assumption that one unified public sphere is always preferable. In unequal societies, a single public often absorbs subordinated groups into norms already set by dominant publics. Instead, she argues that a "multiplicity of publics" can be preferable to one single public sphere (Fraser, 1992: 122). Her key concept is "subaltern counterpublics", which she defines as parallel arenas where subordinated groups "invent and circulate counterdiscourses" (Fraser, 1992: 123). This important development shifts the argument away from the idea that democracy always depends on one shared space of discussion. Fraser shows, instead, that in unequal societies, more inclusive participation may depend on the existence of multiple publics in which marginalised groups can develop their own languages, identities, and political claims before entering wider debate.

Thus, conflict becomes central to democracy rather than something accidental. In Habermas' model, disagreement is ideally resolved through rational-critical debate oriented toward the common good. Fraser does not reject deliberation, but she is more suspicious of unity when dominant groups set the terms of unity. She provides an important example of feminist counterpublics, where feminist media, publishing, conferences, and activist networks developed language for experiences that had often been unnamed or dismissed. These included sexism, sexual harassment, domestic violence, reproductive rights, and unpaid care work. On this view, multiple publics do not mean democracy has failed. In unequal societies, they may actually be needed for more equal participation.

However, Fraser's model also raises a difficulty. If public life is dispersed across multiple publics, it becomes less clear how these different voices are brought together into shared democratic decision-making. In this respect, Habermas remains useful because he preserves the idea that democracy also needs some common arena of public reasoning.

Her third point is about the public/private divide. In the bourgeois public sphere, issues linked to family, sexuality, care, reproduction, and domestic life could be treated as private matters rather than public concerns. Fraser argues that this boundary is political, adding that a more adequate public sphere must include, rather than exclude, "interests and issues that bourgeois, masculinist ideology labels 'private' and treats as inadmissible" (Fraser, 1992: 137). This is a crucial part of her critique, because it shows that exclusion does not happen only through limited access or unequal participation. It also happens through deciding in advance which issues are allowed to count as public at all. The effect of this is that gendered harms can appear personal or domestic rather than social and political. Domestic violence, reproductive rights, unpaid care work, and sexual harassment show clearly why the public/private boundary cannot be treated as natural or innocent. Fraser is therefore stronger than Habermas, not only because she makes room for more voices, but also because she widens the range of issues that can become matters of public concern.

This is also the point at which Fraser becomes central for analysing media and cultural politics. If media help shape what becomes visible and publicly meaningful, they are also involved in drawing the boundary between what is treated as public and what is pushed back into the private sphere. Consequently, the media do not simply reflect public opinion. They also shape which experiences are taken seriously and which problems are recognised as matters of public concern.

In *Culture and the Public Sphere*, Jim McGuigan makes this connection explicit by treating culture as a matter of public debate, policy, identity, and power. For him, the public sphere is not one neutral arena: "There is no single public sphere to which we all have access" (McGuigan, 1996: 4). This supports Fraser's argument that cultural politics is not only about whether groups are represented, but about who has the power to define public meanings and make identities legitimate. McGuigan (1996: 180) also argues that Fraser "reconciles a cultural politics of difference with an updated conception of the public sphere". This makes Fraser particularly valuable for understanding feminist, anti-racist, queer, and diasporic media politics, where the struggle is often over who can define reality in the first place.

In addition, John Thompson extends public sphere theory to mediated societies, while Richard Collins and Paddy Scannell make this more concrete through their discussion of media institutions. Thompson (1993: 188) argues

that public sphere theory must be rethought for mediated societies, especially where “information and symbolic content circulate through global networks”. Scannell’s article ‘Public service broadcasting and modern public life’ presents the positive case, describing broadcasting “as a public good that has unobtrusively contributed to the democratization of everyday life” (Scannell, 1989: 136). Yet Collins’ article ‘Public service versus the market ten years on: reflections on Critical Theory and the debate on broadcasting policy in the UK’ shows why this cannot be accepted uncritically: public service broadcasting has often been a “top down” system, while markets can be captured by “corporate power” and undersupply marginal audiences (Collins, 1993: 250, 258).

This argument applies even more clearly to contemporary media. Digital culture often looks less like one national public sphere than a field of overlapping publics and counterpublics. Building on these earlier examples, feminist, anti-racist, queer, disability-focused, and diasporic media spaces can use social media to circulate experiences, develop shared vocabularies, and challenge mainstream representations. For instance, digital feminist activism such as #MeToo helped turn experiences often treated as private into public and political claims, allowing women to share testimony, build collective language, and challenge dominant accounts of gendered power. This fits Fraser’s (1992: 123) claim that counterpublics enable subordinated groups “to formulate oppositional interpretations of their identities, interests, and needs”. However, digital visibility should not be confused with democratic inclusion. Online participation may appear open, but visibility is still shaped by algorithms, moderation, platform design, advertising, and data extraction. This is why Fraser remains especially applicable in the present. Her framework helps explain why contemporary publics are unequal and contested even when they appear more open than before. McGuigan (1996: 183) captures this danger well when he warns of a possible “phantom public sphere”, where media can simulate participation without creating genuinely equal public communication.

To answer the essay question directly, I conclude that Fraser’s critique ultimately offers a more inclusive and convincing framework to a large extent by explaining exclusion and inequality more effectively than Habermas’s model. However, its force depends on the problem Habermas first made central: how democratic societies can organise public communication. Moreover, Habermas offers a powerful ideal of rational-critical debate, public opinion, accountability, and media as institutions through which citizens can scrutinise authority. This remains valuable because it shows that exclusion from public debate is not only a form of cultural misrecognition but also a democratic failure. Nevertheless, Fraser shows that Habermas’s bourgeois public sphere cannot be treated as genuinely universal. Its apparent openness was shaped by class, gender, race, status, property, education, and the exclusion of issues defined as private. In turn, Thompson, McGuigan, Collins, and Scannell demonstrate the importance of this in mediated societies, where public life is shaped by broadcasting, markets, digital platforms, and struggles over who gets to speak and whose concerns become public. Therefore, Fraser should be understood not as simply rejecting Habermas, but as reconstructing public sphere theory for unequal and mediated societies. Her critique transforms the public sphere from an idealised space of universal reason into a contested field of participation, counterpublic formation, and cultural struggle. This is what makes her critique not only more inclusive but also more relevant for analysing media and cultural politics today.

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